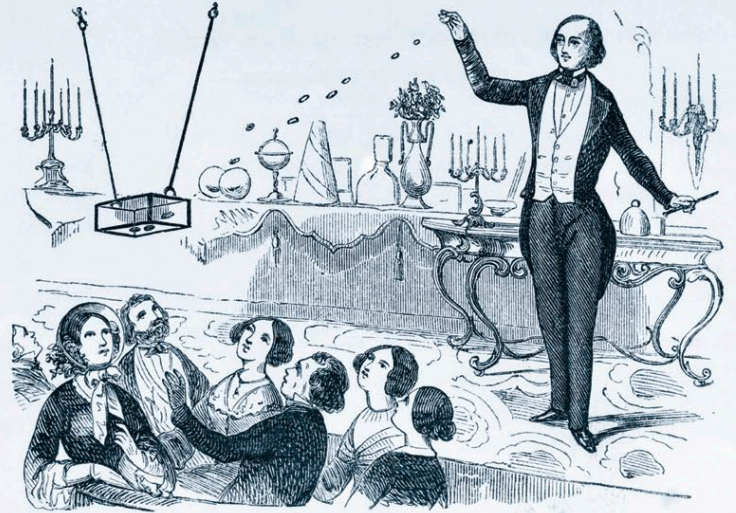




Le Voltigeur au trapèze.



Le Coffre de cristal.

of the North”; John Nevil Maskelyne, who devised the first levitation act and played London’s Egyptian Hall for 31 years straight; and Frenchman Alexander Herrmann, “Herrmann the Great,” who, complete with an immense curling moustache and goatee, was famed for his version of the bullet catch (a trick that has killed at least 12 magicians to date).

Science and illusion

In 1862, a British scientist named John Henry Pepper stunned audiences at London’s Royal Polytechnic by producing a ghost. Three years later he patented his Proteus Cabinet, a staple of stage magic ever since, which involved a figure disappearing and startlingly reappearing from a wooden box—a trick achieved, like the ghost, by the use of mirrors. In the same year Colonel Stodare, “the Summoner of the

Sphinx,” used the same technique to magically make a living head appear inside a small box. Equally mystifying was the first Vanishing Lady act, which was performed in 1866 by Frenchman Buatier de Kolta and made use of a trapdoor in the stage.

None of this was magic in the supernatural sense. Nevertheless, its blend of science, extreme illusion, and a new kind of showmanship left audiences demanding more.

“A magician is an actor
playing the part of a magician.”

JEAN EUGÈNE ROBERT-HOUDIN, *SECRETS OF CONJURING AND MAGIC*, 1868

IN PRACTICE

Phantasmagoria

During the mid-18th century, the charlatan Johann Schröpfer used a magic lantern to project images of spirits onto clouds of smoke during séances. Schröpfer’s fame was such that Paul Philidor, who first used the technique in a public show in 1790, initially called his illusions “Schröpfer-esque Ghost Appearances.” By 1792, however, he had named them *phantasmagorie*. A Belgian, Etienne-Gaspard Robert, perfected the art a few years later, and phantasmagoria became a popular feature of 19th-century stage magic.

The wonder of optics is shown in this German magic lantern, 1872.

